EPSOM U3A Inc.

epsom1u3a@gmail.com

Website https://u3aepsom.nz/.

MEETING PLACE

Royal Oak Bowls, 146 Selwyn St, Onehunga

10am on the 2ND Thursday of most months

NEWSLETTER

July 2026

Next meeting
10-12noon
Thursday, 9 July 2026

The Epsom branch of u3a currently has 199 members and twenty-seven interest groups. We meet and interact in various places; Ryman Village at Logan Park and the Deaf Centre, for example. But very frequently, we meet in other people's homes. There, we talk, debate, laugh, enjoy ourselves and often partake of our host's morning or afternoon tea. It's a commonplace – something we do all the time. So often in fact, that we can become nonchalant about being in someone else's private space.

And that's exactly what a home is. When we go through that front door, we cross a threshold where the outside world ends and an inner world begins. Every home is different; it's personal, intimate and special. It's been said that the home is the geography of the self and reveals who we are. I think there's a lot of truth in that. We are all on show in our own homes.

I also think it's a privilege to be invited into someone's home. So does everyone I've met at u3a. We all respect and appreciate the hosts and members of our groups who open their homes to us and give of themselves.

This is a thank you to them.

Ian Jost
President

EPSOM U3A EXECUTIVE

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Charmaine Strang – 027 4177 556
Interest Group Co-ordinators
Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680
Bill Hagan – – 021 611 247
Guest Speaker Organiser:
Ian Jost – 027 488 7037
Legal Advisor
Mike Matson – 022 630 7968
Newsletter
Jeanette Grant – 638 8566
Greeters:
Don Buchanan 0275 928 131

INTEREST GROUP CONVENERS

Applied Sciences
Peter Parsons - 021 521446
Attending Performing Arts
Shirin Caldwell – 630 1662
Architecture
Brian Murray – 021 026 68396
Art Appreciation
Kaye Buchanan – 021 299 0709
Art History
Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094
Big History
Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094
Book Chat
Helen Holdem - 021 260 3510
Chess Group
John Locke - 021-187 8061
Comparative Religions
Duncan MacDonald - 021-316 661
John Locke- 021-187 8061
Current Affairs
Shirley McConville – 622 3542
Fabric & Fibre Crafts
Charmaine Strang – 027-4177 556
Famous & Infamous Group
Shirley McConville – 622 3542
Foodies
Graham Gunn – 027 445 0929.
Garden Appreciation
Betty Townley - 626 6673
Introduction to Family History
Bryn Smith – 027 280 5235
Latin
Phyllis Downes – 630 5867
Lunch Bunch
Shirley McConville – 622 3542.
Music Appreciation
Carleen Edwards – 624 6298
History & Social Change
Helen Holdem – 021 260 3510
NZ History
Kaye Buchanan – 021 299 0709
Philosophy
Jocelyn Hewin - 634-1552
Scrabble
Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680
Stories of the Past
Jeanete Grant – 638 8566
Te Reo Maori
Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487
Travel
Diana Hart- 021 284 4402
Walkers & Talkers Group
Don Buchanan – 0275 928 131.

JUNE SPEAKER REPORT	Our June speaker, John Locke, shared his in-depth knowledge, his love of history and his long-standing fascination with the Tudors. He explained the background that led to the marriage of Catherine of Aragon to Henry VIII; a decision by Henry's father, Henry VII, to strengthen the links between Britain and Spain, after the death of Catherine's young husband Arthur, who was Henry VII's older son. This marriage in 1509 would provide security against the French for Britain, and create an alliance between two devout Catholic royal houses within the Holy Roman Empire, in the face of the growing Lutherism in Northern Europe, that was emerging at the time. Henry was also driven to marry by the imperative to produce a male heir to the throne of England, thus ensuring the continuance of the Tudor line. Catherine of Aragon's many unproductive pregnancies and the birth of their daughter Mary, (later called Bloody Mary), led Henry, after 23 years of marriage, to seek annulment via a dispensation from the Pope, so he could marry Anne Boleyn in the hope that she would produce the desired male heir. When this was not approved, Henry declared himself the leader of a new Church of England, and while still a devout Catholic himself, took retribution on those who still celebrated the Roman Pope as the leader of the Holy Roman Empire. Henry's people were required to attest to an oath of allegiance to his English church, and the King as its supreme leader. Immense destruction of England's monasteries and confiscation of their wealth ensued, destroying England's ancient religious and cultural history. Many of those who refused to sign the oath were executed, including Henry's counsellors, Thomas More, Thomas Cromwell, Bishop John Fisher and John Houghton. This bold move also allowed Henry to annul his marriage to Catherine of Aragon and marry Anne Boleyn. Sadly, for the clever and cultured Anne, she suffered miscarriages, the death of a baby boy and her living child was a girl, who later was to become the formidable Queen Elizabeth I of England. Catherine and Mary were treated badly and banished from court, Mary losing her right to succession, as she was regarded as illegitimate after the annulment. In May 1527 Henry appeared before Cardinal Wolsey, charged with co-habiting with his dead wife's brother and the validity of the papal dispensation was questioned, though Catherine had always insisted that her marriage to Arthur was never consummated as they were only 15 years old and had been married for only four months before Arthur's death. Anne had become an obstacle to bearing a male heir and was not popular. She also opposed aspects of the dissolution, was interested in religious reform, and after not producing the required male heir, there were accusations of adultery, witchcraft and incest with her brother, while traditional Catholics accused her of being a heretic and husband snatcher. The trial was a farce with trumped-up charges and a pre-ordained outcome, leading to Anne's being restrained in the Tower of London and her execution two days' later. Her marriage had lasted three years. Henry was now free to marry his third wife, Jane Seymour, who bore him a son, Edward, though sadly, he died aged 9, after the death of Henry. There was no issue from his other three wives (Anne of Cleves, Katherine Parr and Katherine Howard, who all had short marriages.) Therefore, after the childless Queen Elizabeth I died, her reign lasting from 1558-1603, the Tudor line ended. Joslyn Squire
EXCHANGE TABLE	Please take home any of your unchosen items on the Exchange Table.
MAIN SPEAKER	Our speaker for July is Colleen Brown. Colleen is a teacher who has taught in London, South Auckland and in the tertiary sector. She was a Manukau City Councillor for nine years and an elected member of the Counties Manukau DHB for 15 years. She has been involved in the disability sector since the birth of her son who has Down syndrome. She lobbied to have the Education Act changed to admit disabled children into the schooling system as of right. In 2019 she was honoured by the Attitude Trust in being the only non-disabled person to be inducted into the Attitude Hall of Fame.

	She is passionate about South Auckland. In her community roles, she meets people from all walks of life who share their stories on current issues affecting New Zealand. In her writing, Colleen especially focuses on South Auckland, youth, and the disability sector, hearing from people who often have little to no voice in the media. She chairs several local community organisations. She is the Chair of Disability Connect, a regional organisation supporting families who have disabled children and is a Board member of Neighbourhood Support NZ. In 2001 she was awarded the MNZM for services to community and education. In 2024 she was awarded the KSO for her contributions to community, and disability. In more recent times she has gone back to her main love, writing. She is the author of *The Bulford Kiwi. The Kiwi We Left Behind*, an historical work that reveals what happened to our New Zealand soldiers waiting for repatriation home at the end of WW1 and tells the story of the construction of the giant Kiwi still visible on the slopes of Beacon Hill above Sling Camp in Southern England. This is the tale she will outline to us. PS It is one of the few hill figures in Wiltshire that is neither a white horse nor a military badge.
HELPFUL HINT	The Council app 'Snap, send, solve' which was advertised at the June branch meeting, has been used by at least two committee members who reported it as excellent with very quick feedback and remediation from the Council.
INTEREST GROUPS	**Big History:** Big History has morphed from the Ancient History group run for many years by John Locke. This recent iteration introduces a new component which is a half-hour lecture watched on a big screen. Those lectures follow the history of mankind by looking at our social evolution on a world-wide basis rather than focusing on one region at a time. This allows us to take into account the influences of one region with other regions, and also a greater emphasis on co-operation and climate/geographical changes over time. After morning tea, someone (who has earlier volunteered) leads the group in discussing or considering one topic arising from the lecture. The volunteer is given notes of what the lecture will cover in advance. This topic can be anything at all triggered by the lecture – it can be an event or an interesting person at the time. Because we are well looked after with technology at the Deaf Centre, these discussions can also include looking at something relevant on You-tube. We have a lot of laughs. If you don't feel comfortable leading a discussion, you can make up for it by bringing a snack twice rather than once during the year. Emily Flynn, Convenor Please contact Bill Hagan to arrange when to speak and/or write about your Interest Group
REMINDERS	1] Please remember to wear your name badge 2] Please be seated by 10am. If you have hearing difficulties, sit near the front and make sure you are not on the end of a row out of the direct line of hearing. 3] After the meeting, could you – if possible – please remove your own chair to the side to be stacked.
2026 MEETING DATES Thursdays, 10am	9 July 13 August 10 September 8 October 12 November AGM **NB Always wear your name badge** and be seated ready at 10am

Kia ora,

I am a PhD student at the University of Waikato undertaking a national study titled When to stop driving? An exploration into driving cessation decision-making among people with cognitive impairment.

This research started in 2023 and I am currently recruiting families, whānau and carers who are supporting an older person with memory loss or cognitive impairment who is either still driving or has recently stopped driving. Participation involves completing a short online survey, which takes approximately 15–20 minutes.

I would be very grateful if your organisation could support recruitment by sharing the study flyer and survey link through any relevant newsletters, mailing lists, networks, community contacts or social media channels. This is currently being executed through the networks of Dementia New Zealand, Carers New Zealand, New Zealand Association of Gerontology, HOPE Foundation for Research on Ageing and more organisations.

This study aims to better understand how families and carers experience decisions about driving cessation, and how support around this difficult transition could be improved.

I have attached an approved flyer for your reference and looking forward to a wider participation from across New Zealand. Your assistance would be extremely valuable in helping the research reach families and carers who may have relevant experiences to share.

If there are possibilities to support the survey distribution, I will be happy to provide further details including the participant information sheet and survey link for circulation.

Thank you for considering this request.

Kushalata Baral - PhD Candidate, University of Waikato, Hamilton, New Zealand

PORTABLE BATTERY-POWERED FILTRATION SYSTEM

California-based startup Vital Lyfe says its first product, a portable battery-powered filtration system, can provide safe drinking water from any source on demand – including seawater.

The cooler-sized Access can process 12 gallons (45.5 litres) of fresh water per hour, or up to 6 gallons (22.7 litres) of ocean water per hour. The idea is to make potable water available for off-grid living, water-scarce regions, disaster relief situations, and defence forces operating in challenging conditions. The contraption measures 20 x 9 x 8 inches (508 x 230 x 205 mm), weighs 25 lb (11.3 kg), and can run off its built-in 210-Wh battery for up to three hours on a full charge. It can also do its job continuously with a 200-W AC/DC power source.

Developed by former SpaceX engineers, the system automatically regulates pressure and filtration, and manages energy performance on its own – so all you need to do is push a couple of buttons to use it.

The system includes a pump for piping water in and out, a reverse osmosis membrane to remove impurities and salts from pressurized water, and a UV-C exposure chamber to neutralize bacteria and microorganisms in the filtered water. There's also an output sensor that monitors water contamination levels before dispensing it.

The system is designed to be easy to set up and use without training. Vital Lyfe claims the device should last you about 6,000 hours if you're filtering saltwater, and even longer if used in freshwater environments. Naturally, you'll need to replace the membranes from time to time; there's an app for that, as well as monitoring the Access' functions and ordering additional membranes directly from the company.

The Access is currently available to pre-order at $749, with shipments expected to go out later in 2026. The company is targeting a 6-month to 1-year membrane life, depending on source water quality and usage patterns. High particulate or biologically active water may impact its life. These are expected to cost $30 each, and should be easy to swap out. At this price, it could be worth considering for people who camp and hike in remote areas for several days at a time, as well as for first responders in disaster-prone regions. It might be out of reach for communities in developing countries, but hopefully Vital Lyfe will be able to optimize its product to make it more widely accessible over time.

Source: Vital Lyfe via PR Newswire

GLUCOSAMINE CAN ACCELERATE ALZHEIMERS DECLINE

People with Alzheimer's disease (AD) who took the common supplement glucosamine were 25% more likely to die within five years than those who didn't.

Glucosamine is a sugar molecule that's sold over the counter as a remedy for joint pain and arthritis. We found that glucosamine also affected people in the earliest stage of memory loss, a condition called mild cognitive impairment. People in this early stage of dementia who were taking glucosamine were 25% more likely to progress to full AD.

Our analysis of patients with AD was based on anonymized medical records from the University of Florida Health system. We included 24,000 patients with dementia and 41,000 with mild cognitive impairment, comparing people who took glucosamine with those who didn't.

We then conducted experiments in mice engineered to have Alzheimer's-like symptoms to identify the potential mechanism behind how glucosamine may affect the brain. We found that blocking the enzyme that makes sugars like glucosamine improved dementia symptoms in mice. In contrast, feeding those same mice glucosamine made memory loss worse. Healthy mice given the same supplement showed no effect. Source – Nature Metabolism

A SELF-SUSTAINING, SELF-CONTAINED, DRY TOILET SYSTEM POWERED BY NATURE.

Kazuba toilets are engineered with a patented system that operates without water, chemicals, or electricity. At the core of this technology is Kazuba's desiccating system—a watertight, dry toilet solution that utilizes natural elements to process waste efficiently.

The system employs a constant airflow mechanism, leveraging temperature and pressure gradients to facilitate the evaporation of urine and the dehydration of solid waste. This process significantly reduces waste volume, making the system highly efficient and low-maintenance. Liquids are separated from solids, allowing natural aeration to evaporate urine and dehydrate solids, reducing volume by up to 90%. A wind-driven vent and thermal chimney work together to maintain continuous airflow. Fresh air is drawn through the pedestal while odours are extracted, ensuring an odour-free experience. This passive ventilation system works without electricity, chemicals, or bulking agents—maximizing capacity and minimizing maintenance.

Constructed from recyclable materials, Kazuba toilets are designed for durability and environmental sustainability. The cabins are built with heat-treated Thermowood pine, providing exceptional resistance to the elements and ensuring longevity.

This innovative approach results in a toilet system that is odourless, easy to use, simple to clean, and requires minimal maintenance, offering a sustainable and efficient alternative to traditional flushing toilets. It was invented in France in 2000

NEAR EXTINCTION

Humans have been around for a while, but we haven't always been an abundant species. In fact, ancient humanity was almost wiped out around 900,000 years ago and the global population dwindled to a mere 1,280 reproducing individuals, a study claims. And the researchers also claim that they stayed like this for 117,000 years…

The researchers used a statistical method and gathered genetic information from 3,154 present-day human genomes. They found that around 98.7% of human ancestors were lost. The researchers say that the population crash matches with a gap in the fossil record. They say this could have led to a new hominin species that was a common ancestor of modern humans, or Homo sapiens, and Neanderthals

The exact cause is unknown, but it is thought that the near-extinction has been blamed on Africa's climate getting much colder and drier…The researchers say that the signature of this bottleneck can be seen in the genetics of people with non-African heritage. Therefore, it would have been hundreds of thousands of years before humans migrated outside of Africa.

The bottleneck also coincided with dramatic changes in climate during what's known as the mid-Pleistocene transition. At this time, glacial periods became longer and more intense, leading to a drop in temperature and very dry climatic conditions. However, the researchers also suggested that the control of fire, as well as the climate shifting to be more hospitable for human life, may have led to a later rapid population increase around 813,000 years ago

https://www.msn.com/en-nz/news/other/human-population-nearly-went-extinct

TREES MINE GOLD

In Finland, an astonishing discovery is captivating the scientific community: Norway spruce trees appear to be producing gold, but not in the way one might imagine. Thanks to the action of invisible bacteria nestled in their needles, gold dissolved in the soil is transformed into metallic nanoparticles integrated into the structure of the leaves.

Researchers from the University of Oulu and the Geological Survey of Finland analyzed the needles of 23 spruce trees near the Tiira deposit. They found gold nanoparticles deeply embedded in the plant tissues, protected by matrices of bacterial biofilm. Unlike simple atmospheric contamination, the gold is actually produced inside the plant through contact with specific bacterial communities.

This mechanism, called biomineralization, consists of a controlled precipitation of minerals by endophytic microbes living in symbiosis with the tree. These microbes use plant fluids to transport dissolved ions from the soil to the needles where the nanoparticles gradually form.

Although the amount of gold contained in each tree is minuscule, this discovery revolutionizes the way gold deposits are located. Instead of exclusively exploring rocks, scientists can now "read" the chemistry of trees, which act as biological indicators of the metals present in the soil.

Furthermore, this green microbial interaction paves the way for ecological methods of mine remediation. By mobilizing precipitating bacteria, it becomes possible to stabilize heavy metals and reduce the environmental impact of mining operations. Thus, spruce trees become both sentinels and potential agents for restoring contaminated soils

CHANGES TO OCEAN CURRENTS THREATEN US ALL.

In 1992 a cargo ship carrying toys was caught in a storm in the Pacific which swept containers holding 28,000 rubber ducks into the ocean. The ducks have since turned up all over the world. Scientists later used their paths to uncover how powerful ocean currents really work.

Ocean currents fall into two main categories. Surface currents control the motion of the top 10% while deep ocean currents mobilise the other 90%. This explains the hidden system moving heat and water across the planet, including the massive "global conveyor belt" deep beneath the ocean's surface. They affect each other in an intricate dance which keeps the entire ocean moving.

In the open ocean, wind is the main force behind surface currents. It pulls on top layers of water which in turn pull on deeper layers. In fact water as deep as 400 metres is still affected by wind at the ocean's surface. Thanks to the Earth's rotation, these surface currents form huge loops called gyres which travel clockwise in the Northern Hemisphere and counterclockwise in the Southern Hemisphere. This is called the Coriolis Event.

The deeper currents are driven mainly by changes in the density of seawater. As it moves towards the Poles it gets colder and also has a high concentration of salt because the ice crystals that form trap the salt and the heavier cold water then sinks and warmer surface water takes its place. This vertical current is called thermohaline circulation. The result is the Global conveyor belt which is the longest currenton Earth.

However, as global temperatures rise, scientists warn that this crucial current may already be slowing down — with potentially serious consequences for Earth's climate and weather systems...

https://www.msn.com/en-nz/weather/topstories/a-cargo-ship-lost-28-000-toys-in-one-storm-then-scientists-realized-